To retain Taj's status as a top-end luxury brand, the upscale luxury hotels were classified as 'Taj' hotels. The objective was to impart the Taj brand an image where it could be 'viewed as a dynamic, emerging, Indian Asian brand, while retaining an association with its heritage and the grandeur that came from several of its iconic luxury properties and palaces'. It was hoped that with the Taj 'investing in and successfully managing five-star hotels abroad', it would 'enhance its brand image as a quality luxury hotel operator'.

The other three tiers served to fulfil different demands. The immediate tier below the Taj was occupied by the 'Vivanta by Taj' hotels. Though its standards were somewhat lower than that of the luxury brand, these hotels were nevertheless meant for the discerning clientele who were aware of the chain's links with the Taj. It comprised the upscale hotels of the group.

The next tier was the three-star category of hotels, and the Gateway brand that was already in existence was brought within its ambit. It would serve the discerning clientele of the middle segment. The last tier was the Ginger brand, a name that was selected by Ratan for two-star budget hotels. He inaugurated the first under this category, the 'indiOne' Hotel in Whitefield in Bangalore in 2004. It was targeted to fulfil the demands of the second and tertiary cities; adopting the 'bottom of the pyramid' approach of C.K. Prahalad. It soon became IHCL's fastest-growing segment. These last two, Gateway hotels and Ginger hotels, were decoupled from the Taj tag and known simply as IHCL hotels.

'Each brand had a different philosophy and a standard to live up to,' says Misra. They had their separate management teams, separate brand heads, chefs and finance teams. They also had separate F&B offerings including specialized cuisine, quality and excellence. Standards of silos were created.

The rebranding was, however, a very arduous task as it involved around fifty to sixty hotels. It spawned challenges too. It caused heartburn amongst the staff of the third and fourth tiers, as they stood to lose the prestige associated with working in an institution that had the famous 'Taj tag'. Owners of some properties were also piqued. Some of them, including the members of erstwhile royal families were particularly upset with the rebranding and needed a lot of convincing, says Misra. It was a 'battle' to 'win over partners, owners of properties, customers, and our own employees', says Bickson.